

Anna Hope: Telling Stories To Change Things [C1]

Il genere tutto britannico del romanzo di campagna permette a questa scrittrice di affrontare numerosi temi legati all'attualità e alla storia del Regno Unito.



Anna Hope started her career as an actress with roles in various TV shows, including Doctor Who. She then turned to writing and in 2014 published her first novel, *Wake*. This powerful historical novel is set over five days in 1920 and explores the lives of three British women, and those around them, [in the wake of](#) the First World War. Since then, Hope has written four more best-selling novels: *The Ballroom*, about a love affair in an Edwardian mental hospital; *Expectation*, exploring friendship and rivalry between three women in their thirties; *The White Rock*, set in Mexico; and now her latest, *Albion*, a modern-day country house novel.

COUNTRY HOUSE DRAMA

Albion is set in Sussex in the south-east of England over five days in spring in the early 2020s. It tells the story of the Brooke family, who are reuniting at their family [estate](#) for the funeral of the patriarch, Philip. Hope is a fan of country house novels like the works of Jane Austen. In *Albion*, the Brookes' twenty-bedroomed country house with its one thousand acres (over four hundred hectares) of land and beautifully-designed gardens becomes the immersive world of the book. Now that the patriarch is dead, the nature restoration project that [eldest daughter](#) Frannie has been running on the [estate](#) is under threat as she faces a large inheritance tax bill and challenges from her siblings about how they should use the land. Frannie's brother Milo dreams of building a luxury therapy centre for the super-rich, where clients will take microdoses of psilocybin, a naturally-occurring psychedelic compound present in some mushrooms. Her sister Isa doubts the family should own the [estate at all](#). And their mother Grace can't wait to leave the huge house with its painful memories. With [tensions already running high](#), a surprise guest at the funeral causes the whole family to question who really owns anything. They also face some uncomfortable truths about where the Brooke family's money originally came from. The interior of Kenwood House in London. The stately home has profound links to the 18th-century transatlantic [slave trade](#) through its owner, Lord Mansfield, and his mixed-race great-niece, Dido Elizabeth Belle, who was raised there.

CLIMATE ACTIVISM

Hope is actively [engaged](#) with issues around the climate and ecological emergency and this is a central theme of her recent books, particularly *Albion*. In 2019, she co-founded the [NGO](#) Letters to the Earth, [aimed at raising awareness](#) of environmental issues and encouraging people to get more [engaged](#). She is involved with the climate action movement Extinction Rebellion and in 2019 was arrested for civil disobedience during a protest in London. Hope believes that storytelling, in whatever form, plays a powerful role in helping people imagine a sustainable future for the planet. She puts this into practice in *Albion*, where

environmental issues are explored in the context of a [gripping](#) family saga. While on a book tour in Barcelona to promote her novel, Anna Hope spoke to Speak Up about some of the issues she explores in the novel. Hope begins by explaining where the idea for Albion came from. **Anna Hope (English accent):** I'd come home from being in Mexico into [lockdown](#) in March 2020. And my marriage was ending and my dad was dying, and so I had a lot of [grief](#). And I was writing this quite [weighty](#) novel. I mean, I think [I'm always drawn to weighty](#) themes, but I remember it was just the most beautiful spring. And so I was walking in the countryside in Sussex where I live, I was so glad to be home, and I thought I want to write something which is supremely local. So actually, Albion takes place about half a mile from where I live. People

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FIVE DAYS

The story takes place over five days. Hope talks about why she chose this [tight](#) structure. **Anna Hope:** I did it with my first book, which was a book about [grief](#) and the First World War, the [aftermath](#) of the First World War. And there's something about [channelling](#) big stories into short [time frames](#) that really appeals to me as a writer because it gives you a really robust frame that you can then be held by. Because I think in approaching the themes that I'm approaching in Albion, I needed something that was going to hold me. And the five days suggested itself as this, yeah, five days in a beautiful spring in the English countryside.

FAMILY TIES

Through the character of Frannie, Hope explores the difficult balance between trying to safeguard a child's long-term future and caring for that child in the present. She explains how activism has impacted mother-child relationships in her own family, starting with her mother, who was an activist for the Campaign for Nuclear Disarmament. **Anna Hope:** My mother, she was very [charged](#) by her activism. And it was a powerful thing, because she was a mother of four and she didn't work. And so to see her [charged](#) and [lit up](#) by her activism was an inspiring and also challenging thing for a young girl, because I could see there was something that she cared about almost more than us. And it was related to her love for us. And so I have tried, as far as I've been able to, to not replicate that so much with my daughter, but I certainly did when I was involved with Extinction Rebellion. I mean, I remember the moment before I got arrested, calling my ex-husband and saying, "I'm going to stay and I'm going to be in a police cell, I think. I don't know for how long." And he said, "Go for it." You know, he was very supportive because he knew how involved I'd been. But obviously my daughter

was a real concern in that moment as well. She was three at the time. Members of the environmental group Extinction Rebellion, which promotes non-violent direct action and civil disobedience, during a protest in London's Oxford Circus in 2019.

INSPIRATION

Hope talks about the real people who helped inspire various characters in Albion — the powerful Brooke family, who own the [estate](#), and Ned, who lives a simple, hippy life in a [van](#) on their land. **Anna Hope:** I grew up in the rave culture of Manchester [and] around the UK. And through that, not only met the sons and daughters of the [ruling class](#) in those same anti-capitalist [demonstrations](#) in the late '90s, but also I met characters like Ned who have [forged](#) a life on the margins. And I've always found the Neds of this world inspiring and they have the capacity to [weave](#) a life on the margins with very little, but it's often a very rich life, and I think a life with many clues as to how we might have to live in the [not-too-distant](#) future.

LAND OWNERSHIP

The question of who (if anyone) has a right to own land is central to the story, as Hope explains. **Anna Hope:** Still [the question remains](#) of who owns the land, and I'm also very interested in whether landowning, concentrated into so few hands, is itself just. And so I wanted to bring in the history of enclosure into the book as well, because just as we were perpetrating the horrors of colonialism [beyond our shores](#), in Britain we were also dispossessing our rural poor by enclosing land, and that's exactly what's happened to the [estate](#) in the novel.

SLAVERY RICHES

The second major theme in Albion, which interconnects with that of the climate emergency, is ownership of land. The [estate](#) at the centre of the book is owned, at least under British law, by the Brooke family. We find out that the private land within the boundaries of the [estate](#) used to be common land that could be used by local villagers for their animals. Then, in addition, the family are shocked to discover that the money used by their ancestor Oliver Brooke to build the house in the 18th century was accumulated through his involvement with the transatlantic [slave trade](#). A diagram of the Brooks (or Brookes), a British slave ship launched in 1781. This ship carried enslaved African people on a brutal journey across the Atlantic.

THE BROOKES

By choosing the name Oliver Brooke for this fictional character, Hope brings to mind a real [slave trader](#) called Joseph Brooks. In the late 18th century, abolitionists used the example of Joseph Brooks' notorious slave ship to help persuade Parliament to [outlaw](#) slave trading. In recent years, historians have found evidence that many country houses, which like the Brooke [estate](#) were built in Britain during the 18th and 19th centuries, were [funded](#) by [proceeds](#) from the transatlantic [slave trade](#). The National Trust, a British [heritage](#) and [conservation charity](#), owns many of these houses, which are open for the public to visit. Recently, the National Trust has been investigating links between the [slave trade](#) and properties it owns. Hope talks about how this investigation carried out by the National Trust inspired her to explore the links between the [slave trade](#) and British country houses, and include this storyline in the novel. **Anna Hope:** The National Trust holds an exceptional number of houses and land, and at a certain point the National Trust [commissioned](#) an audit into links between their houses and the transatlantic [slave trade](#), and also the East India Company. And there was an enormous amount of [pushback](#) in the press against this report, which was simply stating facts that certain houses had been built with money from either plantation owning or other facets of the transatlantic [slave trade](#) and the East India Company. And the [pushback](#) came, I would say, mostly from the right-wing press, but the narrative was, "How [dare](#) you attempt to destroy our [heritage](#)?" And so within that sort of narrative, it was very clear that there was an idea of a sort of brand... the British brand, I would say particularly the English brand, is very tied to the English country house. A huge amount of tourists visit an English country house when they come. Also, we export it brilliantly with our novels and with our adaptations of novels. And there was this idea of sort of [outrage](#) that the National Trust might be telling the truth. And I thought, "God, how interesting. How [willing](#) are we to turn towards this?"

RESEARCH

Hope spent time researching the history of slave trading and its legacy in Britain. As she explains, she was shocked to find that the families of former slave owners were still being compensated by the British government. **Anna Hope:** There was the incredible work of the academics at University College London on the transatlantic [slave trade](#) database, and that was where families could search for their ancestors. And that was information compiled at the time of abolition, so the sort of early 19th century. But I heard something that completely shocked me, which was that the British [taxpayer](#) was still paying back to families for the compensation of their property, [in inverted commas](#), up until, I think it's worth checking this, 2015. So even the [framing](#) of human bodies and souls as property had continued within British conception of what reparations were. And the

reparations were not to the people who were considered property, but to the people who were considered their owners up until well into this century. Absolutely [breathtaking](#). And I think if you ask the average British person on the street if they knew that that was happening, they wouldn't, and I'm sure they would have been [outraged](#).

Glossary

- **estate** = tenuta
- **raising awareness** = sensibilizzare
- **gripping** = avvincente
- **lit up** = entusiasta
- **conservation charity** = organizzazione benefica per la conservazione
- **framing** = impostazione, inquadramento
- **engaged** = impegnarsi
- **I'm always drawn to** = sentirsi attratto da
- **not-too-distant** = non troppo lontano
- **beyond our shores** = oltre i nostri confini
- **pushback** = resistenza, opposizione
- **taxpayer** = contribuente
- **at all** = affatto, per niente
- **tight** = ristretta
- **outlaw** = vietare, mettere al bando
- **funded** = finanziare
- **breathtaking** = mozzafiato
- **eldest daughter** = figlia maggiore
- **grief** = dolore
- **aftermath** = indomani, periodo successivo
- **time frames** = archi temporali
- **charged** = carica di energia, intensa
- **in inverted commas** = tra virgolette
- **the question remains** = la domanda rimane
- **proceeds** = proventi, ricavi
- **heritage** = patrimonio
- **tensions already running high** = la tensione è alle stelle
- **NGO** = ONG (Non-Governmental Organisation)
- **aimed at** = volta a
- **van** = furgone
- **ruling class** = classe dirigente
- **forged** = forgiare, creare
- **weighty** = di grande peso emotivo
- **channelling** = incanalare
- **demonstrations** = manifestazioni
- **slave trade** = tratta degli schiavi
- **dare** = osare
- **outrage** = indignazione
- **willing** = disposto
- **lockdown** = confinamento

- **weave** = tessere
- **commissioned** = incaricare
- **in the wake of** = a seguito di